

CHICAGO REVIEW

The End of (Hi)story

Author(s): Gianni Vattimo

Source: *Chicago Review*, Vol. 35, No. 4 (1987), pp. 20-30

Published by: [Chicago Review](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/25305376>

Accessed: 05-03-2016 14:43 UTC

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.



Chicago Review is collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *Chicago Review*.

<http://www.jstor.org>

The End of (Hi)story

Probably, one of the most important points on which the descriptions of the postmodern condition agree — no matter how different they are from other points of view — is the consideration of postmodernity in terms of “the end of history.” Jean-François Lyotard’s main thesis in *La condition postmodern* is that what characterizes this condition is the fact that it is no longer experienced within the framework of any one of the *metarécits* that used to explain and legitimate existence in previous epochs, above all, modern existence, and, specifically, nineteenth-century culture.

Not only Lyotard but also his main critic, Jürgen Habermas, sees postmodernity in these terms. If the notion of a postmodern condition has a meaning at all for Habermas, this meaning is clearly the disappearance of the *metarécits* as ways of legitimation. Of course, Habermas maintains that this is not, nor does it have to be, the case; we are *not* in the postmodern condition; to assume that we are would amount to an abdication of the critical task of reason. Habermas accepts, in a way, Lyotard’s description; but in his view, it is not the description of the condition of contemporary man but simply a (wrong) interpretation of this condition that involves a more or less explicitly passive acceptance of the existing disorder of late capitalism, technology, and mass society.

Both Lyotard and Habermas argue on the basis of an interpretation of modern and contemporary history: Lyotard (I refer to one of his most recent texts, the paper published in *Critique*, no. 456 [May 1985]) maintains that the *metarécits* — which, in the philosophy of history of the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, were used to describe and legitimize historical existence — have been confuted by decisive events of our time. So the *metarécit* of the rationality of what

is real (Hegel) has been confuted by Auschwitz; the *metarécit* of the socialist revolution, by Stalin and his gulags; the *metarécit* of the free-market economy, by the recurrent crisis in capitalist societies; and the *metarécit* of democracy, by May 1968 (see p. 563 of the cited issue of "Critique"). Habermas, of course, does not deny the tragic reality of these facts; simply, he does not believe that they have "confuted" anything; in his view, they simply represent nondefinitive defeats of the project of the Enlightenment – a *metarécit* that Habermas believes in strongly, assuming that it has been continued by Hegel, Marx, and Max Weber's theory of rationality. It would appear that, at the very end, Habermas is not so much interested in maintaining a historicist view of history; in other words, he appears rather, as the defender of a sort of Kantian rationality more than as the defender of historicism. I do not think that "reason," in the meaning it had for the Enlightenment and has for Habermas, can be considered apart from the historical project of the emancipation of mankind. In very rough terms, I would say that Habermas is not interested in defending reason for the sake of science and of an "objective" knowledge of reality; on the contrary, what he wants is historical *emancipation* through rational critique and also through science. This simply reflects, in my view, the fact that, in the recent centuries of modernity, reason – at least for Continental philosophy – has always been tied to history. Not only for Hegel, but also, in a different sense, for all modern European philosophy (e.g., positivism) it is true that the only way of experiencing reason as the capacity of reaching a *Grund* on which to "build" is only the capacity for grasping the rationality of historical development. (This is probably simply another implication of the very idea of modernity as a "normative" term: modernity can be defined as the epoch in which being modern is the supreme value; but this can be maintained only on the basis of the identification of the *Grund* with the rationality of historical development, as is visible in its most articulated form in Hegel's metaphysics of history.)

The incapacity of postmodern thought to offer a rational critique of the present conditions of society, and, more generally, to provide a basis for any rational discussion, which is the main reason why Habermas disagrees with Lyotard, is clearly related to the fact that, in postmodernist thought, the *metarécits* have been dissolved. Rationality is equal to historical rationality, that is, to a *metarécit*. The postmodern mind, in the view of Habermas, is incapable of providing the basis for a rational critique because it no longer believes in a possible rational course of history – that is because, for it, the *metarécits* have been confuted. It remains true that, for Habermas as well as for Lyotard, postmodernity can be described mainly in terms of the end of history. (I think this can be also true of Richard Rorty's view of post-

modernity. When Rorty says that postmodernity, at the very end, is only “l’oubli graduel d’une certaine tradition philosophique,” which involves a diminution of the importance of philosophy in society, a [reductive] readjustment of its position among other social practices [See *Critique*, no. 442, pp. 194–97; and no. 456, p. 580], he should also recognize that the main effect of the change of the position of philosophy in culture is exactly the dissolution of a unifying point of view on history [I think of Nietzsche attributing to Socrates the “invention” of the notion of universal history]. In other words, we can speak of *a* history only as far as we conceive of humankind as a unique species, developing toward ends, etc. — all ideas that are hardly conceivable outside a philosophical framework).

Let me briefly summarize these introductory remarks: first, I wanted to point out that there is a general agreement as to the meaning of the very notion of postmodernity. If this notion has a meaning at all, it has to be described in terms of the end of history. What is finished is not simply a certain view (or a set of views) of history but history itself. If the *metarécits* that made it possible for us to think of history as a unitary course have been confuted, as Lyotard assumes, history itself has become impossible. To imagine that history, as a course of events, keeps going on no matter what we feel about the *metarécits* we used to believe in would amount to assuming that the specific *metarécit* that conceives of history as an *objective* course of events has not been dissolved; or, in other words, that the course of history, as a unitary and continuous course of events, is not “simply” a *metarécit* but the true description of the very reality of history. Now, this is exactly what the *metarécits* used to claim and exactly what postmodern consciousness does not believe any more. This, by the way, is not only an extravagant idea of postmodernist theorists like Lyotard; recent theory of historiography (e.g., the “metahistorical” research of H. White) has clearly pointed out the “rhetorical” character of the schemes by the means of which we reconstruct the past. These rhetorical models affect the very substance, as it were, of history — not simply the way we experience it, because the distinction between an objective history and a subjective view of it can be described as a rhetorical scheme as well. . . . Under another point of view, if we think of Nietzsche’s critique of *Historismus* and Walter Benjamin’s *Theses on the Philosophy of History*, it is easy to see that history as a unitary course has also become inconceivable (and impossible) because of the increasing complexity of the relations between the centers (of power, but also of cultural critique) that collect and order information about what is going on. Once we have discovered the rhetorical and the power-relation implications that lay at the basis of (the notion of) history as a unitary course of events, history becomes impossible, both

in its notion and in its pretended objective development. If we do not live any longer within the framework of one or another *metarécit*, we no longer live historically—we have entered in that condition that already A. Gehlen had called *post-histoire* (many traits of which could also be described by developing Marshall McLuhan's idea of the global village and similar themes).

The second point I was trying to make in these introductory remarks was that there seems to be an agreement among theorists (again, both Lyotard and Habermas) that, in the postmodern condition, there is no longer a possibility of arguing and rationally “proving” conclusions. This is indeed the thesis of Habermas, but Lyotard also seems to agree, at least in the sense that he assumes that postmodernity also involves a radical transformation of subjectivity and therefore of the very notion of rationality and of rational critique, too. (This radical transformation is seen by Lyotard as related to the new conditions of existence which seem to lead toward a new interpenetration of nature and man, which recalls Renaissance naturalism retrieved in a phenomenological framework. See the recent exhibition *Les immatériqux*, planned and directed by Lyotard at Beaubourg in Spring 1985.) These are then the two ideas I am going to discuss and elaborate in this paper: that of postmodernity as the end of history and that of the problems of legitimation (concerning the possibility of a rationally founded critique), which seems to be raised by this definition of postmodernity.

Let me take my start from an observation concerning the way Lyotard argues about the postmodern condition. He says, for instance, in the paper published in “Critique” I mentioned above, that the *metarécits* have been confuted by the dramatic events that mark our century: so Auschwitz has confuted the Hegelian idea of the rationality of history; Stalin, the idea of the proletarian revolution, and so on. It seems to me that these events acquire the capacity of confuting those *metarécits* only if they are included within the framework of another legitimizing *metarécit*. By themselves, they could not possibly confute anything. I am not raising the trivial objection of self-inconsistency against Lyotard. What is important to me is to observe that he (as well as Habermas, by the way) still uses a procedure of *historical* legitimation in arguing that the *metarécits* have been dissolved. Facts such as Stalinism or Nazism confute metaphysical philosophies of history only because, paradoxically, they are assumed to belong to a sort of rational development, namely, the development of a postmodern condition. The dissolution of the *metarécits* is itself a (paradoxical) kind of *metarécit*. To point out this paradox does not necessarily involve the rejection of Lyotard's theses. On the contrary: only by recognizing the paradox shall we be in the position to dissolve

Habermas's objections by preparing a solution of the problem of legitimation that surely has not been completely dissolved by the dissolution of the *metarécits*.

In the paradox that we must recognize in Lyotard's theory of postmodernity, it seems that postmodern thought simply experiences in its own way the same "contradiction" that is visible, for instance, in Nietzsche's idea of the eternal recurrence (which, as K. Loewith has shown, is to be "instaurated" by a *historical* decision that is not itself a repetition of the past) or in Heidegger's view of the relation of postmetaphysical thought to past metaphysics. Unlike these eminent predecessors, Lyotard seems to pay too little attention to the paradox in which he is captured. He does not see (and would probably not admit) that his theory of the confutation of the *metarécits* is itself a *metarécit*. He assumes that this confutation is an accomplished fact, an event that is completely behind us. The *metarécits* of the past metaphysics of history have been dissolved, and do not mean anything more to us. In his paying no attention to the paradox of the (*metarécit* of the) dissolution of the *metarécits*, Lyotard reminds me of a page of Nietzsche's *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, where Zarathustra's animals describe the eternal recurrence in too easy a form—they sing and dance, chanting, "Everything goes [an anticipation of Feyerabend's anarchism?], everything comes back, eternally rolls the wheel of being." Zarathustra blames them for having transformed such a terrible and serious idea into a hurdy-gurdy song. The animals, he says, have forgotten all the pain he had to suffer (described in another discourse, of the same third part of the book, "On the Vision and the Riddle") in order to become able to think (or to instaurate, or to accept) the idea of the eternal recurrence (*Thus spoke Zarathustra*, part 3, "The Convalescent").

It is exactly in authors such as Nietzsche and Heidegger—who, of course, also belong to the theoretical background of Lyotard's theory of postmodernity—that we have to look for a more productive way of paying attention to the paradox on which postmodern theory is based. In this paper I am not developing this discourse as far as Nietzsche is concerned (for this see the last chapter of my book *La fine della modernità*, 1985). I will simply try to show how some key concepts of the late Heidegger—namely, the concepts of *Andenken* and of *Verwindung*—can help us go farther into the meditation on postmodernity and its problem of legitimation.

The problem Heidegger faces in his effort to overcome (*überwinden*) metaphysics is in many senses the same Lyotard is confronted with when he tries to "prove" that we are living in a postmodern condition and that the *metarécits* have been confuted. But while Lyotard, as I suggested above, takes this confutation as an accom-

plished event which does not require further consideration, and which has put us in a totally new condition, Heidegger explicitly recognizes that metaphysics cannot be left behind us as an error we have got rid of (which, in the terms of Lyotard, would have been confuted). This impossibility is not only a matter of psychological habits (metaphysics as the thought in which we grew up, etc.); nor is it simply the consequence of the lack of a nonmetaphysical language (as Heidegger argues in the *Letter on Humanism* when he explains why *Sein und Zeit* remained unfinished). Both the psychological and cultural difficulty and the lack of a nonmetaphysical language are to be brought back to a more radical reason: metaphysics cannot simply be overcome because to overcome it would mean to perpetuate its methods and structures. To overcome metaphysics would mean to “confute” it, to reject it on the basis of a more adequate foundation, substituting a new truth for the old error: but this would be exactly the way to continue metaphysical thinking. The difficulty that Lyotard reveals in his trying to confute *metarécits* by the means of another *metarécit* can be considered a confirmation of this thesis.

Exactly because he is acutely conscious of this difficulty, Heidegger thinks that the only way to step out of metaphysics is not by critical overcoming (or confutation) but by *Verwindung*. I am not going to discuss here all the meanings and implications of Heidegger’s use of this word. I just want to point out that it involves a complex set of notions that go from “distortion” (which is the most important for my purpose here) to “healing,” “convalescence,” “resignation,” “acceptance.” Metaphysics can only be *verwinden* in all these senses: we can step out of it only by accepting it with resignation, as a sort of illness whose traces we still bring in ourselves; but taking it this way will also be a distortion of its original purposes and claims. If we apply the notion of *Verwindung* to modernity and postmodernity (an application that is justified by the fact that, for Heidegger as well, modernity is just the last result of metaphysics, its “practical” aspect in the moment of its accomplishment), we shall say that postmodernity is the epoch that has a relation of *Verwindung* (in all the sense of the word) to modernity. A postmodern thought, as that of Lyotard, brings in itself the trace of the historicism that characterized modernity; Lyotard can corroborate his argument for the postmodern condition only by bringing in historicist procedures of legitimation, which he should recognize more explicitly; this recognition could help him develop the theory of postmodernity in a more productive way.

In which sense, more precisely, can we say that postmetaphysical (or postmodern) thought is a *Verwindung* of metaphysics (or of modernity)? In what does *Verwindung* consist? Heidegger’s late works show how this distortion has to be viewed: what they do is carry on the

program of the destruction (or deconstruction) of metaphysics that was already announced in *Sein und Zeit* by the means of the recollection of its turning points, that is, by the means of a retrieval of the whole metaphysical tradition. It would be a mistake to believe that this retrieval or recollection intends to grasp what has remained unthought of in metaphysics, something that has been forgotten and should be remembered, brought back to the presence of representation. What remains unthought in metaphysical tradition is the *Ereignis* character of Being, Being as an event and not as a stable structure like Plato's *ontos on*. What the recollection achieves is the recovery of this "eventual" character of Being: metaphysics appears to Heidegger as the "series" of the epochs in which Being has opened itself in the form of different *archai*, each one claiming to be a stable (metaphysical) structure while it was "just" an "epochal" openness, a sort of *episteme* in Foucault's sense. This recollection of metaphysics in "archeological" terms (see the recent book by R. Schürman on *Le principe d'anarchie*) is a distortion of it because it deprives metaphysics of its authoritarian character, disregarding its claims to being a knowledge of the stable principles of reality.

Retrieving metaphysics in archeological terms is also what Heidegger calls *An-denken*—recollection, the very essence of postmetaphysical thought. Recollection does not reach any ultimate evidence, any stable foundation. As a matter of fact, Being conceived of as an event cannot be grasped as a presence, as a stable ultimate structure beyond the errors of metaphysics; Being is not, but "happens" (es gibt Sein = Es, Sein, gibt) and can only be "thought" of in the form of recollection, as something that is always already gone. Postmetaphysical thought cannot "overcome" metaphysics through a new foundation; it can only celebrate, in relation to metaphysics, "feasts of memory," as Nietzsche says more or less in the same sense as Heidegger. Being is not presence but *Ereignis*, event, and *Ge-Schick* (the aggregate, *Ge*, of the sending, *Schicken*); therefore, thought is not (is no longer) foundation but *An-denken*, recollection. *Andenken* is a distortion because it deprives the metaphysical *archai* of their ultimacy, thinking of them within the framework of the eventuality of Being.

With the emphasis he puts on recollection, Heidegger seems to be very close to much of postmodern sensibility: think of the tendencies toward a free—even arbitrary—revival of the forms of the past; this revival, in architecture and in other artistic fields (the novel, for instance), is not inspired by the idea of an analogy between our epoch and one or the other epoch of the past, an analogy that would justify the evocation of these forms in order to find *adequate* examples for the art of today. Past form and stylistic traits are evoked and revived outside of any kind of foundational motivation; they are just a reper-

tory of rhetoric *exempla* that are not intended as the basis for a more adequate understanding and expression of the present situation.

But, to come to a provisional conclusion, how can we say, as I said before, that this way of referring to the past in a *verwindend* or *andenkend* way can help us solve the problems of legitimation in post-modernity?

The question is also justified because, at least in Heidegger, to whom I especially refer here – but this could also be said of Nietzsche, as far as his thought tends to develop itself in a “genealogical” form – recollection, seen as the “authentic” possibility given to postmetaphysical thought, seems to take totally the place of what, in metaphysics, was the search for the ultimate foundation. Recollection is the form in which thought “corresponds” to Being conceived of in terms of event, *Geschick*, *Überlieferung* (trans-mission) of historically qualified disclosures. It is an attitude of this kind that Nietzsche describes in *Human all too Human* as the attitude of the “good tempered man,” who, having discovered that all metaphysical, moral, and religious “values” are only the result of the sublimation of impulses, interests, and so on, does not simply reject these values but looks at them with an attitude of “limited” respect, which I think can be described by the Latin term of *pietas*; *pietas*, in this context, would describe the attitude of devoted attention that we adopt toward the values marked by mortality and finitude. The only kind of foundation that is at our disposal in the age of the end of metaphysics, from a Heideggerian point of view, seems to be this appeal to the inherited “values” – works of art, institutions, language, and so on, more or less what Hegel called the objective spirit – seen as “monuments,” that is, as something that lasts and provides us with “valid” ways of approaching experience, but only within the horizon of mortality and perishability. “Was bleibet aber, stiften die Dichter,” says Hölderlin as quoted by Heidegger: what lasts is founded by poets. This endurance is not to be conceived in terms of an eternal duration, not even in terms of the perfection of the classical work of art in Hegel’s sense (which also involves a certain kind of eternity), but in terms of historical monumentality, which is ultimately related to the notion of trace and of mortality. What *remains* – traces, monuments, graves, that is, residues in a certain sense – opens itself in poetry.

I think it is easy to see how this conception of the foundation in terms of recollection can claim to be a *Verwindung* of the foundational thought of traditional metaphysics. By implicitly but strongly attributing a normative character to the events that have “confuted” metaphysical *metarécits*, Lyotard was calling for respect and attention toward *what happened*, assuming that it shall be considered a decisive indication for theory and thought. Habermas refuses Lyotard’s con-

clusions, but only by appealing on his side to another course of events that, he assumes, contains another, equally cogent indication for theory. To explicitly substitute recollection and *pietas* for this still-foundational thought means, in the first place, to deprive this “foundation” of its claims to logical congruency and demonstrative power. Nietzsche’s words “God is dead” is only the announcement of an event, not the metaphysical description of a structure of being in which God would not possibly “exist.”

But, again: does this distortion, or *Verwindung*, of the metaphysical practice of foundation represent a way of solving the problems of legitimation that face postmodern philosophy? It seems that *Verwindung* succeeds indeed in unmasking the still metaphysical character of postmodernist theories, such as that of Lyotard (but it is hard to see how it could provide us with positive alternatives).

In a sense, it is true that there is no alternative solution. This is what is meant by the word *Verwindung*—which is, in my opinion, a key word to describe not only philosophy, but also, for example, the political “chances” of postmodern culture. The only way we have to argue in favor of postmodernist philosophy is still an appeal to history, as those we have seen in Lyotard and Habermas. Only if we recognize this fact explicitly and make it the theme of our reflection, instead of pretending that it is now completely behind us as a *vergangen* event; that is, only if we tell explicitly, again and again, the story of the end of history, shall we be able to change, distort, *verwinden*, its still metaphysical significance. Somebody (K. Rosenkranz, I think, in one of the first works on philosophical anthropology, quoted and discussed by K. Loewith in one of his essays) has observed that the only real way we have to distinguish between sleep and wakefulness is that, when we are awake, we can remember that we have woken up. Nietzsche is right when he says (in *The Twilight of Idols*) that the true world at the very end became a fable; but fable and simulacres, if they have to be recognized as simulacres and not be given the weight and authority of a new sort of platonic *ontos on*, have to be kept in a *verwindend* relation toward the “true” world of metaphysics. If we simply assume, as an indisputable fact, that the events of our time have completely dissolved and liquidated the *metarécits* of metaphysics, we really remain, as Habermas says, without the slightest possibility of a rational critique of the present. On the contrary, if we recognize that, as Heidegger suggests, the end of history belongs to the history of Being, we will still have a criterion—be it paradoxical—for rational arguing and for historical options. Sure, to speak of the history of Being means to appeal again to a cogency of what happened, in the sense that metaphysical historicism (but also Lyotard and Habermas) used to do. We are reviving

here a *metarécit*, the *metarécit* of the history of Being. But, contrary to what happened in Lyotard and Habermas, this *metarécit* is recognized as having the sole meaning of the progressive—as it were—dissolution of all the *metarécits*—that is, of the dissolution of being as a stable structure in favor of Being as an event. To say this is also a way to recognize that Heidegger finally developed a philosophy in which Being (foundation, structure) disappears, takes leave, is gone—and nevertheless he still remained interested in ontology, according to the purpose on which *Sein und Zeit* was based. We can adequately, or authentically, experience the disappearance of Being as an event only within the history of Being; and vice versa. The story of the end of history, in this sense, is both a *Verwindung* (a distorted continuation) of metaphysics (or historicism) and a theory in which the very meaning of the history of Being is *Verwindung*, in all the senses of the word: we could also speak of secularization, de-sacralization (I am thinking here also of R. Girard's idea of Jesus as the unmasker of the "sacred" in its violent implications), God's death in Nietzsche's terms.

As with metaphysical historicism, the *metarécit* of the end of history is also an appeal to correspond to what happened to the history of Being. The distortion, however, consists of the fact that the event that we are to correspond to is a process whose meaning is the dissolution of any *cogency*, as well as the cogency of the history of Being. What we must correspond to is the dissolution of Being itself ("das Sein als Grund fahren lassen," says Heidegger in *Time and Being*, a lecture of the sixties). The normativity that thought is faced with, therefore, is a very paradoxical one—but nevertheless, it claims a specific validity. The "process" to which we are to correspond to is the "epochal," self-concealing (or simply nihilistic) essence (*Wesen* being meant here in the verbal sense Heidegger gives to it) of Being; consequently, the "reasons" why we are to correspond to this destiny of Being are also "distorted" reasons, no longer cogent in the sense that belonged to the metaphysical foundation. We are confronted here with a sort of hypothetical imperative that at the very end depends on the *pietas* I was alluding to above. As a matter of fact—and I am thinking here of some recent positions of Rorty's—if thought can no longer be "foundational thought," the reasons we can offer in order to persuade others to accept the thesis of postmodernism (or any other thesis) cannot be based—as pragmatists seem to think—on the need for survival (which would require agreement, playing the social and language games, etc.); if it were so, the need for survival would represent another form of true and ultimate (metaphysical) foundation. Life, to which we can appeal in order to persuade somebody of the validity of a philosophical thesis, is rather, and is perhaps only, a historically and culturally qualified and "charged" form of life; we are hardly inter-

ested in pure biological survival, but in surviving within a set of “goods,” cultural and human values that constitute our sole being. But the appeal to these historical values is exactly what can be described as *pietas*, in the sense I outlined above.

All this involves plenty of normative content, which can provide the basis for satisfying the reasonable preoccupations of people like Habermas. A postmetaphysical “logic” and “ethics”—not to speak of politics—can be constructed on the notions of *pietas*, *Andenken*, *Verwindung*. What seems to be clear from the very beginning is the *negative* criteria with which they provide us: to correspond to the *verwindend* essence of Being and of thought, we have to engage actively in the de(con)struction of all the metaphysical residues that still are alive in our philosophy, psychology, ethics, culture in general. Let me just make an example: in relation to historically decisive phenomena like Khomeini’s revolution, or Pope John Paul II’s traditionalist interpretation of Catholicism, a postmodernist philosopher would surely be in the condition to choose and judge better than Habermas himself (remember the disastrous mistakes made by left-wing intellectuals in evaluating the meaning of Khomeini’s revolution at its beginning). Maybe the initial, purely negative, normative implications of the (paradoxical) postmodernist philosophy of history (because it is actually one) are not much. But they seem to be the only way to open philosophy in a time when foundational thought has become (fortunately) impossible, and Being as *Grund* is (fortunately) gone.